

THE NET

Reticulum



SIZE RANKING 82

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.3

GENITIVE Reticuli

ABBREVIATION Ret

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
DecemberFULLY VISIBLE
23°N–90°S

Reticulum is a small constellation in the southern sky, near the Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310). It was introduced by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422) and represents the reticule, or grid, in his eyepiece, which he used for measuring star positions.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Zeta (ζ) Reticuli is a yellow double star. Its 5th-magnitude components can be split through binoculars.

THE PAINTER'S EASEL

Pictor



SIZE RANKING 59

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.2

GENITIVE Pictoris

ABBREVIATION Pic

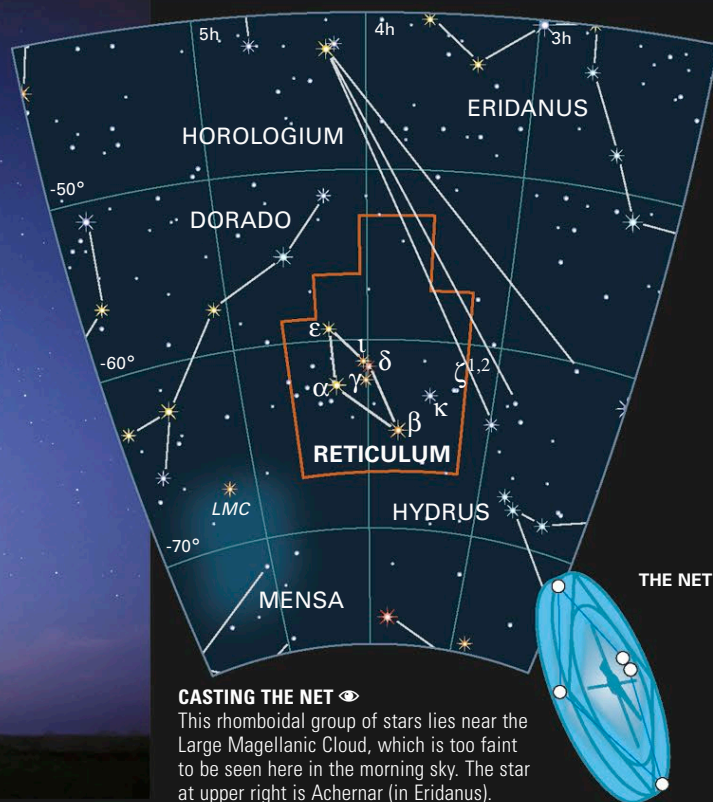
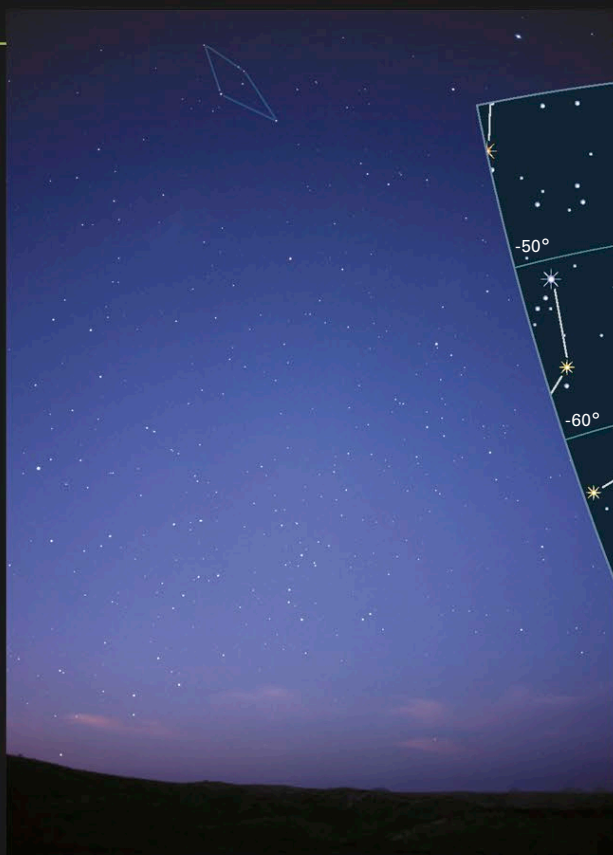
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
December–FebruaryFULLY VISIBLE
26°N–90°S

Pictor was invented by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422), who imagined it as an artist's easel, complete with palette. He originally called it *Equuleus Pictoris*, although that name has since been shortened. It is a faint constellation of the southern sky, and it is situated beside the constellations Puppis and Columba.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

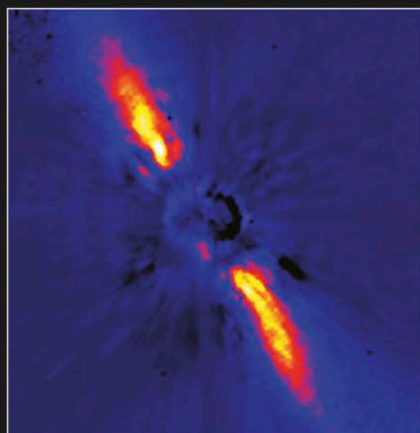
Beta (β) Pictoris is 63 light-years away. It is of special interest because, in 1984, astronomers discovered a disk of dust and gas orbiting this blue-white star of magnitude 3.9. The circumstellar disk is thought to be a planetary system in the process of formation. The planets of our solar system are believed to have developed from a similar disk that existed around the Sun shortly after its formation.

Iota (ι) Pictoris is a double star with components of 6th-magnitude. These are readily separated through a small telescope.



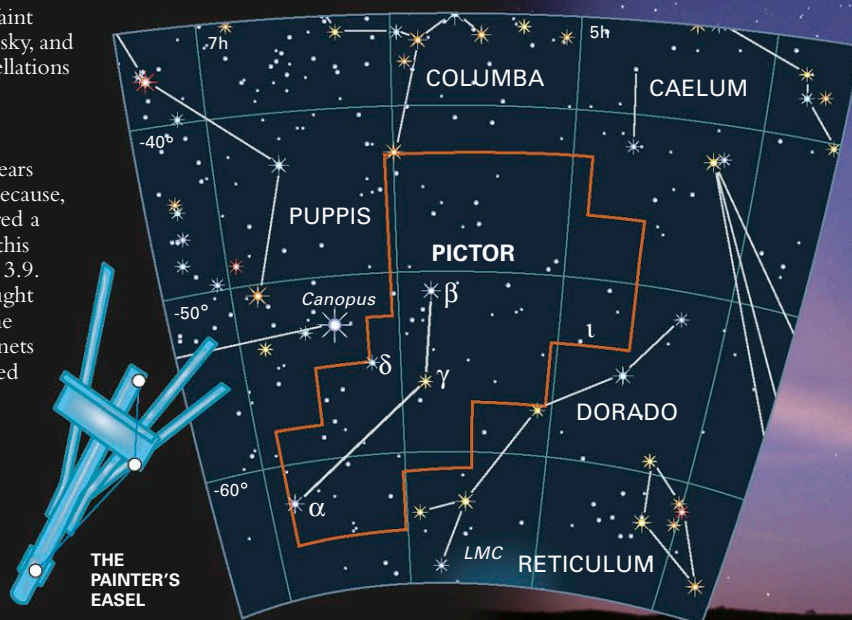
CASTING THE NET

This rhomboidal group of stars lies near the Large Magellanic Cloud, which is too faint to be seen here in the morning sky. The star at upper right is Achernar (in Eridanus).



BETA PICTORIS

The bright areas on this professional false-color image indicate the circumstellar disk. Distortions in the shape may be due to a planetary system forming around the star.



DIVIDING LINE

Pictor consists of little more than a crooked line of stars between brilliant Canopus (in Carina), seen here on the left, and the Large Magellanic Cloud.